



LA BIKE & METRO TRAVEL GUIDE

Pocket Guide • Alhambra Base

November 10–26, 2025

 Trip Summary

🕒 FIRST 48 HOURS PRIORITIES:

- ✓ Purchase folding bike at REI Arcadia
- ✓ Visit Apple Store Pasadena
- ✓ Get Metro TAP card at Atlantic Station

✈ Flight Details

Route: GIG (Rio de Janeiro) → LAX (Los Angeles)
Airline: American Airlines – Main Cabin Economy
Duration: ~14h 22min (via MIA/DFW/CLT)
Booking: aa.com — Request aisle/window seats
Seat Selection: Avoid middle seats and seats near lavatories

🏠 Base Location

- Alhambra, California**
- 8 miles east of Downtown LA
 - Nearest Metro: Atlantic Station (L Line)
 - Famous for Asian cuisine & culture

📞 Emergency Contacts

⚠ EMERGENCY: 911

- **Alhambra Police:** (626) 570-5151
- **Metro Customer Service:** (323) 466-3876
- **REI Arcadia:** (626) 447-1062
- **Apple Store Pasadena:** (626) 817-6820

📄 Essential Info

- **Currency:** US Dollar (\$)
- **Weather:** 60–75°F (15–24°C), sunny
- **Time Zone:** PST (UTC-8)
- **Languages:** English, Spanish, Chinese
- **Sales Tax:** 9.5% on purchases
- **Tipping:** 15–20% restaurants, \$1–2 services

✖ Essential Packing Checklist

Daily Carry:

- Water bottle
- Sunscreen SPF 50+
- Sunglasses
- U-lock + cable
- Metro TAP card

Tech & Safety:

- Phone mount
- Power bank
- First aid kit
- Light jacket
- Bike lights

LA Metro System Overview

LA Metro Map

Key Lines from Alhambra:

L LINE (GOLD)

Atlantic Station
→ Pasadena, Union Station, Chinatown

B LINE (RED)

Transfer at Union
→ Hollywood, Universal City

A LINE (BLUE)

Transfer at Union
→ Long Beach, Downtown

Metro TAP Card Guide

Pass Type	Cost	Best For
TAP Card	\$2	One-time fee
Single Ride	\$1.75	One trip
Day Pass	\$7	Unlimited daily
7-Day Pass	\$25	BEST VALUE

💡 Metro + Bike Tips:

- Bikes allowed on ALL trains & most buses
- Avoid rush hours (7–9am, 4–7pm) when possible
- Bike lockers: \$0.05/day with TAP card
- Folding bikes can stay with you (don't need rack)
- Download: Metro LA app for real-time updates

🕒 Key Destinations & Travel Times

Destination	Line	Time
Pasadena (Old Town)	L	12 min
Union Station (Downtown)	L	20 min
Chinatown	L	15 min
Hollywood/Highland	L → B	45 min
Universal City	L → B	55 min

📱 Essential Apps

- **Metro LA:** Official transit app, real-time arrivals
- **Google Maps:** Navigation, bike routes
- **Citymapper:** Trip planning, multi-modal
- **Yelp:** Restaurant reviews, local recommendations
- **Strava:** Track bike rides, discover routes
- **Komoot:** Outdoor route planning and navigation for hiking, cycling, and running
- **Go Jauntly:** A free community-based walking app
- **REI:** REI Co-op Shopping App

 Bike Tour Routes from Alhambra

Alhambra Bike Routes Map

Key Locations:

-  REI Arcadia (4 mi NE)
-  Apple Store Pasadena (3 mi N)
-  Huntington Library (3.5 mi NW)
-  LA County Arboretum (4 mi NE)
-  Old Pasadena (3 mi N)

Route 1: Alhambra–Pasadena Loop

Distance: 10 miles — **Time:** 1.5–2 hrs — **Difficulty:** Easy-Moderate
Alhambra → South Pasadena → Old Pasadena (Colorado Blvd) → Huntington Library area → San Marino → Return
Highlights: Historic architecture, shopping, gardens

Route 2: San Gabriel Valley Cultural Tour

Distance: 12 miles — **Time:** 2–3 hrs — **Difficulty:** Easy
Alhambra → San Gabriel Mission → Temple City → Arcadia (REI) → Santa Anita Park → Return
Highlights: Historic mission, parks, shopping

Route 3: LA River Trail

Distance: 15 miles one-way — **Time:** Half day — **Difficulty:** Moderate
Alhambra → LA River bike path → Griffith Park → (optional: Burbank)
Highlights: Dedicated bike path, nature, Griffith Observatory

Route 4: Rose Bowl & Arroyo Seco

Distance: 8 miles — **Time:** 2 hrs — **Difficulty:** Moderate (hills)
Metro to Memorial Park → Rose Bowl → Arroyo Seco trails → Lower Arroyo Park
Highlights: Stadium, natural trails, scenic views

Safety First:

- Always wear helmet (available at REI)
- Use front white light + rear red light (required at night)
- Stay in bike lanes when available
- Watch for car doors opening (ride 3ft from parked cars)
- Follow traffic signals – bikes = vehicles

Security:

- ALWAYS lock bike, even for 1 minute
- Use U-lock through frame + rear wheel
- Cable lock for front wheel
- Lock to fixed objects in visible areas
- Take lights and computer with you

★ Top Attractions

🚲 Bike-Friendly (Within 5 miles)

The Huntington Library & Gardens

📍 1151 Oxford Rd, San Marino (3.5 mi)

💰 \$25–30 — 🕒 Wed–Mon 10am–5pm

World-class art, rare books, 120-acre gardens. Reserve online!

LA County Arboretum

📍 301 N Baldwin Ave, Arcadia (4 mi)

💰 \$15 — 🕒 Daily 9am–4:30pm

127-acre botanical garden, peacocks, historic buildings

Old Pasadena

📍 Colorado Blvd area (3 mi)

💰 Free — 🕒 Varies by shop

Historic district, restaurants, shopping, nightlife

Norton Simon Museum

📍 411 W Colorado Blvd, Pasadena (4 mi)

💰 \$15 — 🕒 Wed–Mon 12–5pm

European masters, Asian art, sculpture garden

Gamble House

📍 4 Westmoreland Pl, Pasadena (4 mi)

💰 \$15 tours — 🕒 Thu–Sun

Iconic Craftsman architecture (Back to the Future house!)

🚇 Metro Accessible

Downtown LA Arts District

L Line 20 min

Street art, galleries, Grand Central Market, food scene

Chinatown

L Line 15 min

Authentic dim sum, shops, cultural sites, festivals

Little Tokyo

L Line + walk 25 min

Japanese culture, ramen, MOCA, Japanese American Museum

Hollywood Walk of Fame

L → **B** 45 min

Chinese Theatre, Walk of Fame, Hollywood Sign views

Universal Studios Hollywood

L → **B** 55 min

💰 \$100+ online — Full day adventure

Griffith Observatory

B Line to Vermont + bike/bus

\$ Free (planetarium \$7) — Best sunset views of LA

Alhambra Food Scene

Must-Try:

Alhambra is **THE** destination for authentic Chinese cuisine!

- **Lunasia Dim Sum House:** Dim sum, traditional Chinese dishes
- **Valley Blvd:** 2+ miles of Asian restaurants
- **Din Tai Fung:** World-famous soup dumplings
- **Sam Woo BBQ:** Cantonese roast meats
- **Mama Lu's:** Dumpling house
- **Bubble Tea:** Dozens of shops throughout

Shopping Stops

REI Arcadia (PRIORITY)

📍 **Address:** 214 N Santa Anita Ave, Arcadia, CA 91006

🕒 **Hours:** Mon–Sat 10am–9pm, Sun 10am–7pm

🚲 **From Alhambra:** 4 miles (15 min bike/Uber)

📞 **Phone:** (626) 447-1062

Recommended Folding Bikes (\$300–800):

- **Tern Link C8:** ~\$500, reliable, good for touring
- **Dahon Mariner D8:** ~\$600, lightweight aluminum
- **Brompton C Line Explore:** ~\$1900+ (premium, ultra-compact)

🛒 **Also Purchase:** Helmet, U-lock + cable ([Evolution Mini U-Lock with Flex Cable](#)), lights, water bottle holder, small handlebar bag, bike pump.

Apple Store Pasadena

📍 **Address:** 54 W Colorado Blvd, Pasadena, CA 91105

🕒 **Hours:** Daily 10am–9pm

🚲 **From Alhambra:** 3 miles bike OR **L Line** to Memorial Park

📞 **Phone:** (626) 817-6820

Handy Tips

🚲 Bike Transport on Metro

- Bikes allowed on all trains (4 bike spaces per car)
- Board through wide doors at ends of train
- Folding bikes can stay with you (don't need rack)
- Some buses have front bike racks (2 bikes max)
- Avoid rush hours when possible

TAP Card Purchase Locations

- Atlantic Station (nearest to Alhambra)
- Any Metro station vending machine
- Many CVS, 7-Eleven, Ralphs stores
- tap.metro.net (order online, delivered)

Weather & What to Wear

- November: Perfect weather 60–75°F
- Sunny most days, light jacket for evenings
- ALWAYS sunscreen (UV is strong!)
- Comfortable walking/biking shoes
- Layers work best

Phone & Internet

- Holafly: Travel eSIM with unlimited data - eSIM\$52.90 for 16 days
- Consider prepaid SIM: T-Mobile or AT&T
- Available at airports, Best Buy, carrier stores
- Tourist SIM plans: ~\$30–50 for 2–3 weeks
- Free WiFi: Coffee shops, libraries, Apple Store

Special Dates During Your Visit

- **Nov 11:** Veterans Day (federal holiday, some closures)
- **Nov 28:** Thanksgiving (major holiday, most places closed)
- **Nov 29:** Black Friday (major shopping day, crowds)

Daily Planner & Schedule

Day 1 - Mon, Nov 10: ARRIVAL

Land LAX → Transport to Alhambra → Rest
Evening: Explore neighborhood, dinner Valley Blvd

Day 2 - Tue, Nov 11: GET EQUIPPED

Morning: REI Arcadia (buy bike + gear)
Afternoon: Apple Store Pasadena + Old Town
Get TAP card at Atlantic Station

Day 3 - Wed, Nov 12: PASADENA DAY

Bike to Old Pasadena → Norton Simon Museum
Lunch Colorado Blvd → Gamble House or Rose Bowl

Day 4 - Thu, Nov 13: GARDENS

Morning: Huntington Library & Gardens
Afternoon: LA County Arboretum

Day 5 - Fri, Nov 14: DOWNTOWN LA

Metro to Downtown → Grand Central Market
Arts District → Olvera Street → Walt Disney Concert Hall

Day 6 - Sat, Nov 15: HOLLYWOOD

Metro to Hollywood/Highland → Walk of Fame
Chinese Theatre → Griffith Observatory (sunset)

Day 7 - Sun, Nov 16: LONG BIKE RIDE

LA River Trail to Griffith Park (15+ miles)
Pack lunch, full day adventure

Day 8 - Mon, Nov 17: SAN GABRIEL VALLEY

San Gabriel Valley Cultural Tour by bike
Mission → Temple City → Santa Anita

Day 9 - Tue, Nov 18: ASIAN LA

Metro to Chinatown (lunch) → Little Tokyo
Explore Japanese American Museum

Day 10 - Wed, Nov 19: LOCAL LOOP

South Pasadena & San Marino bike loop
Relax, catch up on local spots

Day 11 - Thu, Nov 20: UNIVERSAL STUDIOS

Full day at Universal Studios Hollywood
Metro there and back, buy tickets online

Day 12 - Fri, Nov 21: BEACH DAY

Santa Monica & Venice Beach
Metro + bike or bus, full day trip

Day 13 - Sat, Nov 22: CULTURE

Getty Center OR LACMA + La Brea Tar Pits
Choose based on interests

Day 14 - Sun, Nov 23: THANKSGIVING PREP

Relaxed day, local exploration
Check Thanksgiving dinner options

Day 15 - Mon, Nov 24: THANKSGIVING

Experience local Thanksgiving
Many restaurants offer special menus

Day 16 - Tue, Nov 25: FINAL EXPLORATIONS

Last minute sights, shopping
Pack, organize bike return/donation

Day 17 - Wed, Nov 26: DEPARTURE

Check flight time → Transport to LAX
Departure home

💡 Planning Tips:

- Book museum tickets online in advance
- Check weather daily, adjust plans
- Rest days are okay – don't overdo it!
- Mix Metro days with bike days for variety

Notes & Quick Reference

Emergency Numbers

 **DIAL 911 FOR ALL EMERGENCIES**

Service	Number
Alhambra Police (non-emergency)	(626) 570-5151
Metro Customer Service	(323) 466-3876
Poison Control	(800) 222-1222
REI Arcadia	(626) 447-1062
Apple Store Pasadena	(626) 817-6820

Key Addresses

REI Arcadia: 214 N Santa Anita Ave, Arcadia 91006
Apple Store: 54 W Colorado Blvd, Pasadena 91105
Atlantic Station: 100 W Atlantic Blvd, Alhambra
Huntington Library: 1151 Oxford Rd, San Marino
LA County Arboretum: 301 N Baldwin Ave, Arcadia

Useful Websites

Metro LA: metro.net
TAP Card: tap.metro.net
LA Tourism: discoverlosangeles.com
Bike Route Planner: Google Maps (bike mode)
REI: rei.com/stores/arcadia
Weather: weather.com or weather.gov

Pre-Trip Checklist

Before You Leave:

- ☐ Book AA flight
- ☐ Print this guide
- ☐ Download Metro app
- ☐ Check passport validity
- ☐ Notify credit card co.
- ☐ Travel insurance

First Day in LA:

- ☐ Get to Alhambra safely
- ☐ Buy folding bike at REI
- ☐ Get Metro TAP card
- ☐ Visit Apple Store
- ☐ Test bike locally
- ☐ Buy groceries/water

Personal Notes Space

★ Top 5 Must-Do Experiences

1. **Huntington Library Gardens** – World-class botanical paradise
2. **LA River Trail Bike Ride** – Unique urban nature experience
3. **Alhambra Food Tour** – Authentic Chinese cuisine adventure
4. **Griffith Observatory Sunset** – Iconic LA views
5. **Metro Exploration** – Downtown, Chinatown, Hollywood

Packing Brompton for Airline Baggage:

📺 **How-To Videos:** Checking the bike as regular airline baggage: [Fly your bike around the world](#). Cardboard box solution: [3 Ways to Fly with your Brompton Bike](#).

🔪 **Coroplast Solution:** Measurements for cutting coroplast: [Packing the Brompton for Air Travel](#).

🛍️ **Also Purchase:** Two IKEA Dimpa Bags: [Ikea DIMPA 3 pcs Extra Large Storage Bag](#). Medium-Length 5mm Hex Key: [L Hex Wrench Set](#).

★ Final Tips for Success:

- Stay flexible – weather and energy levels vary
- Hydrate constantly – dry climate, lots of biking
- Lock your bike EVERY time you leave it
- Take photos but also enjoy the moment
- Don't try to see everything – quality over quantity
- Ask locals for recommendations – people are friendly!
- Save energy for the experiences that matter to YOU

Have an Amazing Adventure! ✈️ ⚙️ 🚲

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Created with ❤️ for your journey